

OBLIVION: GETTING THE BEST OUT OF IT!

When it was released a year ago, *Oblivion* quickly became one of those titles that brought graphics cards to their knees. While the expansive game itself along with the open-ended gameplay have their attractions, it definitely doesn't hurt that the fourth instalment of *The Elder Scrolls* is one heck of a visual experience!

The downside to all the amazing scenery and abundance of HDR effects is, of course, the nosedive in recorded frames per second. Yes, *Oblivion* kills most cards off right away; the few that survive stutter along. Of course, turning down all effects—ditto the resolution—cures this,



Low LOD, textures low, grass off and 250+ fps

but then you miss out on the visual element.

We can't work miracles here. *Oblivion* will not run satisfactorily on anything less than GeForce 6600GT and ATI x800 class cards. While the GeForce 4/ATI 9xxx series aren't supported, the GeForce FX series will stutter at all but the most basic of resolutions. We're assuming you have a decent graphics card.

Besides the numerous options in *Oblivion*'s in-game menu itself, here are some hidden options that can be tweaked. All these are available in the *oblivion.ini* file in your My Documents\My Games\Oblivion directory. We suggest you back up the file!

GRAPHICS SETTINGS

bAllowConsole

Setting the value of this key to 1 will allow access to the in-game console. There's nothing to be gained from keeping it at 0, so you may as well!

ShadowMapResolution

This key determines the resolution of shadows in the world of *Oblivion*. Since shadows can tax older systems a lot, we suggest you keep this value down if you

experience framing. Try experimenting with values between 64 and 256. For those with latest-generation cards, go with 512 or 1024. You can change this number in multiples of eight.

bDoCanopyShadowPass

When this key value is set to zero, it will remove shadows from trees, which can boost fps especially in forested areas.

bUseRefractionShader

Setting this value to 0 will greatly boost frames in areas where transparency effects are used, such as around *Oblivion*

GB, set the values to 6 and 72 respectively. In case of 2 GB, double that—12 and 144, and so on. This tweak works well in conjunction with the next one.

iPreloadSizeLimit

The value here represents, in bytes, the maximum value useable by the game for preloading data. For a system with 1 GB of memory, try doubling the default value. In case of 2 GB, redouble it. However, setting this value too high will cause crashing, owing to extra game data uselessly lying around in memory.

Pretty-pretty Mods:

Here's a little collection of mods to make *Oblivion* look even better, if your rig is up to the challenge. We're assuming



Max details, notice the castle (fog is due to clouds and not textures) 82 fps

Gates, or the shimmering effects around invisible characters.

bAllowPartialPrecision

This specifies whether the shaders run in partial precision DX 9 mode or not. For the best possible image quality, set this to 0. For a decent compromise, set it to 1.

iMinGrassSize

This one controls the density of grass clumps, which are visible pretty much all over *Oblivion* maps excepting interiors of course. The fps will experience a nice boost in areas of dense grass; however, lowering this value too much will thin out the grass too much.

MEMORY SETTINGS

Oblivion is a memory hog too! Here's what you can do to help:

uInterior Cell Buffer and uExterior Cell Buffer

This tweak determines the number of cell buffers for interior and exterior areas of the game. Obviously, exterior areas need more memory. The default setting, 3 and 36, works well for less than 1 GB of memory. In case you have 1

you are already running the game at maximum visual settings and a resolution of at least 1024 x 768.

1. Landscape LOD Replacement 1.1—Visually better distance objects and LOD, this mod is around 28 MB, and is available at

www.tessource.net/files/file.php?id=2182

2. Beautiful Meadows—The regular grass texture in *Oblivion* shows very obvious tiling. This mod reduces the tiling and grassy hillsides look much better as a result:

www.tessource.net/files/file.php?id=2415

3. Higher-resolution landscapes—This mod is large (325 MB) but it effectively updates all the landscape textures with higher-resolution samples, making scenery look that much better. The downside is, it's very resource-intensive, and so only recommended for higher cards in the GeForce 7 and ATI X1800 and X1900 series cards. Available at

[http://planetelderscrolls.gamespy.com/Vie](http://planetelderscrolls.gamespy.com/View.php?view=OblivionMods.Detail&id=708)

4. Coloured map mod—This mod adds colour to the regular drab-looking *Oblivion* world map. Only 3 MB, this one is a must-try! Get it at www.elderscrolls-oblivion.com/index.php?option=com_remository&Itemid=16&func=fileinfo&id=126 ■